

Checkmate: niche fragrances are the perfume industry's new power players.



NOUVEAU NICHE

Discover the latest fragrance trend wafting to a perfume counter near you.

The Christmas perfume push is on: from overzealous spritzers on the department store floor to the generous gifts-with-purchase, they're all competing for your holiday dollar. And while the fragrance industry is still ruled by the big cosmetics companies, there are smaller, lesser-known brands rising through the ranks. Niche fragrance houses produce unique, artisan scents, which, while not specifically intended for the mass market, are growing in popularity. The rise of these brands suggests that consumers are searching for unique signature scents to call their own.

British perfumer Roja Dove, who runs the influential Haute Parfumerie at Harrods in London, believes it's all about a search for individuality. "We've reached a time when everything is about *me* and *mine* and *I can't have the same as you*. For example, when I have a coffee I have to have an extra

shot, skinny latte, cinnamon-topped coffee because that's my coffee, and in the fragrance world we see that trend," he explains. "[By choosing niche] you're showing that you know something and you have hunted it out because it's not readily available."

Michael Edwards, fragrance expert and author of the seminal perfume guide *Fragrances of the World*, believes this is more than just a trend. Rather, he says, it's the beginning of a new age, a shift from the corporatisation of perfume, which sees the power swing from the hands of multinational companies onto the wrists of consumers. ▶

Canturi
EDP, 100ml
for \$195.



Puredistance
perfumes, 17.5ml
vials for \$325 each,
and stand, \$535,
from Vendôme.

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VOGUE BEAUTY

Fragrance connoisseurs, or perfumistas, as he calls them, will blog about a little-known scent and create cult worship overnight.

"We're in a fragmented business: last year we tracked over 1,100 new fragrances ... [People] want something that is different," says Edwards.

In Australia, the support for niche scents is growing as perfume distributors champion smaller brands. David Jones stocks brands from niche distributor Agence de Parfum, including Lubin's Gin Fizz (Grace Kelly's favourite fragrance), alongside crowd-pleasers from Annick Goutal and Tom Ford. Boutique perfumeries such as Brisbane's Libertine Parfumerie and Melbourne's Peony are popping up, and Mecca Cosmetica, a long-time advocate of artisan scents, has just launched a dedicated concept store in Myer Melbourne called Mecca Perfumeries, where fragrance aficionados are on hand to help you find your signature scent. Along with popular scents from Frédéric Malle and Le Labo, Mecca recently added to its stable avant-garde French perfumer Francis Kurkdjian, whose fragranced linen wash and perfumed bubbles have many devoted perfumistas. Even fashion and lifestyle stores are opening their doors to include boutique perfume brands, including luxury store Vendôme in Sydney's Woollahra, which recently picked up super-exclusive Austrian brand Puredistance to sell alongside Boucheron jewels and Swiss watches.

Keeping abreast of this trend, big-name houses are also finding ways to appeal to the customer's desire for individuality by releasing "fragrance collections". Brands such as Les Exclusifs de Chanel, Guerlain's L'art et la Matière, Giorgio Armani Privé and Hermès's Hermessence allow customers to have a unique "me fragrance" while still buying into a trusted brand. Often marketed as being the top-shelf range or under more limited distribution, these collections amp up the rare and exclusive factor, giving the brand an authentic high quality and "boutique" angle.

This month heralds the launch of our very own home-grown boutique brand by Australian jeweller Stefano Canturi, simply named Canturi. Edwards says the scent is an example of niche perfumery at its finest.

The fragrance, which took Canturi two years to develop, was always going to be a passion project. From the beginning, the jewellery designer was adamant about creating something from

the heart, something unique that, like a piece of fine jewellery, would move and inspire the wearer.

"Jewellery is an emotional purchase," says Canturi. "It has the most sentimental value of any product on the market. Here was something that I could directly relate to in fragrance because it evokes memories, it evokes a mood in you."

Inspired by the creativity of the Cubism movement, which forms the basis of his popular jewellery collections, Canturi wanted a scent that would transport the wearer to that expressive state. He and his wife Patricia worked with Kevin Verspoor, a German perfumer based in New York (who previously created bespoke scents for Madonna), and brought Michael Edwards on board as a consultant to help them navigate the rarefied world of fine fragrances.

"It's very difficult for people coming into the perfume industry because the creators and the oil houses have procedures," explains Edwards. "[Canturi] had a very clear idea about the emotion he wanted to convey. He wanted it to have facets, like a jewel."

The finished product is faceted with fragrant memories from Canturi's past. His parents owned a fruit shop, so citrus features heavily, including Calabrian bergamot. He added the first blooms of Sydney springtime jasmine and the warmth of wood, which reminds him of his father's carpentry projects. Spices such as cardamom and pepper give it its oriental classification.

The scent launched to rave reviews at Bergdorf Goodman in New York and Hong Kong's Lane Crawford earlier this year, and is going into Canturi stores and Myer exclusively in Australia.

It's a brand that Edwards wants to see succeed on the world stage. "We have so much marvellous innovation [in Australia] with make-up, like Napoleon and Becca, and skincare – look at Jurlique and Aesop – but it has never happened in perfume," he points out.

In true niche spirit, Canturi's perfume was a personal labour of love, created with meticulous care and designed to appeal intensely to a select few. "I didn't want to please everybody," Canturi says. "And that's exactly what Michael said to do. He said: 'It won't be for everyone, but the ones who love it will really love it.'" ■



Tom Ford
Arabian Wood
EDP, 50ml
for \$290.



Lubin Gin Fizz EDT,
50ml for \$181, from
Agence de Parfum.



Chanel Les
Exclusifs de
Chanel Bois
des Iles EDT,
200ml for \$350.



Annick Goutal
Eau d'Hadrien
EDT, 50ml
for \$130.



Maison Francis
Kurkdjian Lumière
Noire Pour Homme
EDP, 70ml for \$165,
from Mecca Cosmetica.



Editions de Parfums
Frédéric Malle Dans
Tes Bras, 50ml for \$260,
from Mecca Cosmetica.